

in the day. He had seen the French team celebrating. It changed the way he approached his own final.

"I saw the mixed doubles team winning. Everyone was happy, and I saw that, and I was like, I need to win also," Lanier said after his match. "I need to win that one to make them smile and to make them happy."

By then, Lanier was playing for something bigger than himself. "Today was a day for badminton France. I was not really playing for me today. I was playing for the French team. I think we had the whole team behind us from the start of the tournament, even in the preparation before," he said.

That support is a long way from where French badminton began.

Gicquel, at 27, is old enough to recall a time when French badminton didn't have nearly the kind of support it does now. "When we started training badminton as children, there was no money and little support. But we did it because we loved it. Now we are getting money and support, and we are competing at the highest level," he said on the eve of the final.

That change in support is visible throughout the French setup.

Ludvigsen, coach of Gicquel and Delrue, said the team had made the World Championships its number one goal for the year and had spent the three months after the European Championships building specifically towards it.

"We have been working towards this goal since after the European Championships, so for the last three months we've been building and working towards this," she said.

The preparation included a hard physical block and specific work on the conditions in the Delhi arena. The mixed doubles team had taken part in the India Open badminton tournament in January this year and had been knocked out in the quarterfinals after struggling to adapt to slow conditions.

This time, they prepared for them.

"We worked specifically on playing in this hall because we had

already tested it in January," Ludvigsen said.

The preparation was specific to the players as well. They worked on making Gicquel stronger from the back of the court and Delrue faster.

Ludvigsen says France has been devoting significant resources to long-term results. It does not have the enormous player depth of countries such as China, Indonesia or Japan. Managing the workload of its athletes, therefore, was critical.

"In the whole system it's very important that we're managing the load correctly so we are not overtraining. Bigger countries like China can afford it if somebody rips an ACL (ligament). They bring another one in. We can't do that. So we do a lot to keep the athletes that we have," she said.

Gombrowicz makes the same

« **The popularity is growing because the results are getting better** – Kestutis Navickas, Alex Lanier's coach »

point from a wider perspective. France has two world gold medals, more than any other country at this World Championships. But he does not believe that means it has reached the very top of badminton's hierarchy.

"China, Japan, Korea, Indonesia and Malaysia have players capable of competing across multiple events. France does not yet have that depth. China is a very strong country because they are present at all events. It's not the case for France," Gombrowicz said.

France, he says, still has work to do to bridge that gap. "For the French system, we need to put more players in the top 30, and a lot of different events. If we want to be a strong, strong country in badminton, it's a first step. But we have the ambition to go higher," Gombrowicz said.

Increasing popularity

There is another reason for optimism: France's growing player

base. Navickas said there are now around 250,000 licensed badminton players in France, with the popularity of the sport increasing as French results improve.

"The popularity is growing because the results are getting better. Those results, they are just giving the belief to the whole badminton community also that helps to attract the talents and then the system hopefully can make the talents better and better," Navickas said.

For all that optimism, there is one amusing reality. Neither Gicquel and Delrue nor Lanier expects the kind of reception at home that would accompany a French football or basketball triumph.

"We will be welcomed as nobody knows us. We'd like to hope there will be thousands waiting for us back in France, but I don't think that will happen," Gicquel joked after the mixed doubles victory.

He knows the hierarchy of French sport.

"We are really good in so many sports that I think a lot of people will start to follow us and follow badminton, so that's amazing. But it's not like football or basketball or anything," he said.

But while thousands of people may not be waiting at the airport, French badminton is already attracting attention at the highest levels of the State. President Emmanuel Macron publicly congratulated Gicquel and Delrue after their historic victory.

For badminton in France, that is another small sign that something has changed.

Gombrowicz is careful not to suggest the work is finished. "We still have to do a lot more. There are three categories (men's doubles, women's doubles and women's singles) in which we don't have medals. We have to bridge that gap," he says of the French team.

That will take longer. But there is one thing Rubio says France will make sure of at future world tournaments. "We'll make sure not to forget the champagne," laughs Rubio.